The Theological-Ethical Contributions of Archimandrite Sophrony (Sakharov) to Environmental Issues

Perry T. Hamalis

The subject of environmental issues and Orthodox Christianity does not, typically, bring to mind the names of Fr. Sophrony (Sakharov) or his mentor in the spiritual life, St. Silouan the Athonite. Indeed, even those who knew Elder Sophrony personally or who are familiar with his writing would likely not identify "the environment" as a subject on which he had something unique or especially significant to offer. Monasticism, the "person," repentance, prayer, or the spiritual life more broadly, yes—but environmental ethics, no. Having said this, however, we should note, first, that St. Silouan's teachings have been cited within such landmark documents as the Ecumenical Patriarchate's 1990 statement *Orthodoxy and the Ecological Crisis*,[1] and, second, that thinkers including Jean-Claude Larchet, Metropolitans Kallistos Ware, and John Zizioulas have included some analysis of St. Silouan's views on the animal and plant world within the context of more general works on the saint's teachings.[2] In what follows, I will argue that Fr. Sophrony's theological-ethical vision includes teachings that contribute in important ways to Orthodoxy's engagement with environmental issues. More specifically, by drawing from both Fr. Sophrony's published writings and from material collected through interviews with members of the monastic community at Essex,[3] I will defend the claim that it is his understanding of the meaning of the human person that holds together Fr. Sophrony's normative teachings about the nonhuman sphere of creation. I will discuss four areas where Fr. Sophrony's most significant teachings seem to lie: (1) his account (inspired by St. Silouan) of the status of nonhuman and human life, (2) his postlapsarian anthropology, (3) his conservation mindset, and (4) his

teachings on hypostatic prayer. But first, I will begin with a brief biographical note.

Fr. Sophrony: Biography and the Influence of St. Silouan

Fr. Sophrony was born Sergei Symeonivich Sakharov in 1896 to Russian Orthodox parents living in Moscow. From the time of his childhood, Fr. Sophrony was inclined to contemplate metaphysical questions of death, meaning, and eternity.[4] His unquenchable pursuit of the eternal manifested itself in multiple ways. He studied painting at Moscow's Academy of Arts and at the National School of Painting, Sculpture, and Architecture, seeking meaning through artistic expression. He also dedicated between seven and eight intense years to Far Eastern transcendental meditation—something he lamented later in his life.[5] Fr. Sophrony left Russia in 1921 and, after brief stays in Italy and Germany, settled in Paris. Here he enjoyed some success as an artist, exhibiting his paintings in two prestigious Parisian salons. Having returned to the Orthodox faith in 1924 and still on a quest for God, he enrolled at St. Sergius Orthodox Theological Institute, where he met and was influenced by Sergei Bulgakov and Nicholas Berdyaev. The academic study of theology, however, did not satisfy Fr. Sophrony's thirst for the divine, and in 1925 he departed from France for the peninsula of Mt. Athos, where he was to spend the next twenty-two years of his life as a member of the Russian Orthodox Monastery of St. Panteleimon. It was there in 1930 that he met Staretz Silouan, the man who would shape his spiritual life and teachings most profoundly and whose holiness was officially recognized through canonization by the Ecumenical Patriarchate in 1987. For eight years, the monk Sophrony pursued God under the direct counsel of Staretz Silouan, and Silouan, in turn, revealed to Sophrony the details and the wisdom of his spiritual experience. After Silouan's death in 1938, Fr. Sophrony left the communal monastic life for the Athonite wilderness. He was ordained a priest and served as confessor to several Athonite communities. In 1947, Fr. Sophrony returned to France, in part so that he could edit and publish the writings and teachings of his beloved elder.[6] While there, he became a trusted friend of Vladimir Lossky and coedited the periodical *Messager de l'Exarchat du Patriarche Russe en Europe Occidentale.* Prohibited by his deteriorating health from returning to Athos, and at the request of several spiritual children who had gathered around him in Paris, Fr. Sophrony established the community of St. John the Baptist in Essex, England, where today over forty monks and nuns coexist in prayer, realizing concretely the theological-ethical vision he articulated. It was on July 11, 1993, at the monastery he had cofounded

thirty-four years prior, that Fr. Sophrony reposed peacefully. Since then, there has been a steady interest in his theological-ethical writings among Orthodox and non-Orthodox, academics and nonacademics, in the East and the West.[7]

An assessment of Fr. Sophrony's environmental teachings properly begins with a brief consideration of St. Silouan's normative views on the subject. Fr. Sophrony insisted that his first book was strictly a rearticulation of what his elder had entrusted to him. He was—in his language—a mere "postman" delivering the words he had received.[8] While as scholars we might question the possibility of such pure hermeneutics, the point remains: from Fr. Sophrony's perspective, Silouan's teachings were authoritative, inerrant, saving words. "Throughout my time with Blessed Staretz Silouan," he writes, "I never for an instant doubted that his words were the 'words of life eternal.'"[9] Elsewhere he states, "I am not conscious of the slightest resistance to the Staretz' teaching, feeling in my heart that his is the *final* word."[10] While several outstanding voices within Orthodoxy influenced Fr. Sophrony's ethical vision, none affected him as decisively or as unequivocally as St. Silouan.[11]

The Leaf: An Image of Nonhuman and Human Life

St. Silouan's contribution to environmental thought is neither systematic nor detailed. It does, however, reflect a central emphasis on the human person and his or her salvation in a way that clearly continues in Fr. Sophrony's normative vision. Let me note briefly two dimensions of St. Silouan's environmental teachings that carry over in this way, linking them through the image of a leaf.

Fr. Sophrony writes that he witnessed in St. Silouan "an astonishingly harmonious conjunction of seemingly incompatible extremes,"[12] and this was certainly true in Silouan's teachings pertaining to plant and animal life. In a well-known passage, Fr. Sophrony recounts:

> I remember once walking with [the Staretz] from the monastery to [a hermit's hut]. We carried walking-sticks, usual in mountainous regions. On each side of the path there were clumps of tall wild grass. With the idea of not letting the path get overgrown I hit out with my stick at one of the stalks. . . . The Staretz thought this rough of me and shook his head [disapprovingly]. . . . I understood, and felt ashamed of myself.[13]

In his own writings, St. Silouan expands on this point. "The Spirit of God," he writes, "teaches the soul to love every living thing so that she would have

no harm come to even a green leaf on a tree, or trample underfoot a flower of the field."[14] On the one hand, then, St. Silouan both exhibits and calls for a profound sensitivity toward all living things, regardless of species. He is a "preservationist" in a deep and broad sense and to an extent not frequently witnessed among Christian thinkers writing on such themes. For him, the Spirit of God seeks the preservation of *all* life and seeks a response of loving respect toward all living things from *every* human person. Consider another passage from St. Silouan's notebook:

> Once I needlessly killed a fly. The poor thing crawled on the ground, hurt and mangled, and for three whole days I wept over my cruelty to a living creature. . . . [Another time,] it happened that some bats bred on the balcony of the storeroom where I was, and I poured boiling water over them, and once again I shed many tears on this account and since then I have never harmed any living creature.[15]

What Fr. Sophrony takes from these accounts is a radical preservationist attitude toward nonhuman life, one that would seem to lie beyond the reproach of even the most devout environmentalist. Yet what is also clear is that the emphasis here is not merely on the intrinsic value of leaves, flies, or bats but rather encompasses the effect of human responses to nonhuman life upon the spiritual condition and salvation of persons. That is, St. Silouan and Fr. Sophrony seem to be calling for a response within each human being akin to that of a caretaker, a shepherd, or even a priest. To harm *needlessly* part of God's nonhuman creation is to betray this high calling, causing God's Spirit to withdraw. In addition, to understand truly the significance of this betrayal leads to the kind of weeping St. Silouan described above.[16]

The other side of this "radical preservationism" is where the "harmonious conjunction of seemingly incompatible extremes" noted earlier becomes apparent. Put simply, St. Silouan unapologetically prioritizes human persons over nonhuman creation. As an Orthodox monk, he ate moderate portions of vegetables and seafood, harvested hay, and chopped trees for firewood,[17] and there was no dilemma in doing so. Furthermore, St. Silouan writes explicitly against overattachments to animals. In a passage that has scandalized many readers, he states, "There are people who attach themselves to animals, and stroke and fondle and talk to them. . . . It is silly to do this. Feed animals and cattle, and do not beat them—in this consists man's duty of kindness towards them; but to become attached, to love, caress and talk to them—that is folly for the soul."[18] According to Fr. Sophrony, the Staretz considered such responses toward animals (so common and often extreme among pet owners in our society) to be "a perversion of the order established

by God and contrary to the [normative] state of man (cf. Gen 2:20)."[19] Yet here again St. Silouan's core soteriological concern becomes apparent. It is not that genuine caring relationships with animals, including pets, are wrong but rather that extreme anthropomorphisms, he contends, imply a dangerous attachment to earthly things and a distorted prioritization that draws one's mind away from the love of God and neighbor,[20] away from the greatest divine commandment which is—in Fr. Sophrony's view—itself God's uncreated, saving energy.[21]

What seems to be at work, then, is a fundamental difference in status and value between human and nonhuman life in both St. Silouan's and Fr. Sophrony's teachings, and this brings us back to the image of the leaf, but with a significantly different meaning this time. Fr. Sophrony uses a wonderful variety of terms and analogies in order to express the mystery of the human person and the unity of humanity. Because of their Trinitarian grounding, he prefers theological terms like "human *hypostasis*," "*persona-hypostasis*," and "hypostatic principle in man."[22] In several works one finds him invoking such terms to make bold claims about divine-human commensurability, stating, for example, "mankind is one being but multi-hypostatic, just as God is One Being in Three Persons."[23] In other contexts, however, Fr. Sophrony appeals to biological images and describes the entire human race as a "single organism" and—as I have been hinting—as a leafy tree.[24] Consider the following passage from one of Fr. Sophrony's addresses to the monastic community in Essex:

> "Love thy neighbor as thyself." It was given to me to understand this commandment in the form of a gigantic tree, of cosmic dimensions, whose root is Adam. Myself, I am only a little leaf on a branch of this tree. But the tree is not foreign to me; it is the basis of my being. I belong to it. To pray for the whole world is to pray for this tree in its totality, with its milliards of leaves.[25]

For Fr. Sophrony, every human being is a leaf that has grown out of the root of Adam, and, as such, each human person remains ontologically united both to that root *and* to every other leaf on the tree. We will return to the idea of prayer for the "whole Adam" below, but for now two other points should be made that carry environmental implications. First, this extraordinary emphasis on humanity's ontological unity levels a sharp critique upon all forms of individualism. Notwithstanding personal distinctiveness, all of humanity—every human being born in history—is ontologically united. There are so many ethical ramifications stemming from this single, very simple teaching that one would be hard pressed to overstate its significance.

While I will return to this point below, for now we should note that this anthropological claim sheds important light on the meaning of a saving word or spiritual counsel Fr. Sophrony received from St. Silouan and repeated frequently: "*Our brother is our life*."[26] No one is a Christian alone, and no one's spiritual development can occur in a mode detached from other human beings.

The tree image is also important because Fr. Sophrony makes it very clear in other passages that while human beings are like leaves on a tree of the total Adam, organically connected with one another, we are also fundamentally different from actual leaves and from all of the nonhuman creation in a most important way: *among God's creatures we alone are hypostatic*. Flies, bats, and leaves, dogs, cats, and trees are to be respected and should not be harmed unnecessarily, but, since they are not hypostatic beings—not beings created in the divine image—their value remains relative to the earthly realm. To be overly attached to them is to be overly attached to the world. In *His Life Is Mine*, Fr. Sophrony writes, "As the image and likeness of the Absolute, man is conscious that in his spirit he transcends every other form of natural being."[27] And in *On Prayer*, he makes it clear that only hypostatic beings exist in the realm of eternity.[28] Unlike the love of animals or other nonhypostatic creatures, there is no proper limit on love directed to a person—whether divine or human, for to love one's neighbor is to ascend to the eternal realm and, thus, fulfill one's divine purpose. Fr. Sophrony writes:

> [The true ascetic] does not deny the reality and value of the creation. All he does is not to regard it as absolute, not to deify it or consider it an end and a value in itself. God did not create the world in order that He Himself might live the life of the creature. He created it in order to associate man with His own Divine Life. And when man does not arrive at deification, which cannot be achieved without his own collaboration, the very meaning of his existence disappears.[29]

So here, once again, Fr. Sophrony's environmental teaching about the status of the natural world traces back to his understanding of the meaning and salvation of the human person.

The Fall, the Hypostatis, and the Environment

In a rich passage from *His Life Is Mine*, Fr. Sophrony articulates a series of claims about the fallen human condition. He writes:

> In the person of the first Adam, all mankind suffered a fearful catastrophe, an alienation which is the root of all alienations. The body was wounded, the skeleton smashed, the countenance—the image of God—distorted. Succeeding generations have added many another injury and broken bone to the wounds of the first created man. The whole human corpus is sick.[30]

Here we see the graphic flipside of Fr. Sophrony's teaching on the unity of humanity. Yes, each human person remains *homoousios* with every other, but the Fall has effected a fragmentation and infection within the "total Adam's" body. Returning to his tree image, we might say that, according to Fr. Sophrony, the leaves began turning brown—or became diseased—when our forefathers sinned, but we have not fallen off the branches. The point that seems environmentally significant, however, comes toward the end of the passage, where Fr. Sophrony writes, "Succeeding generations have added many another injury and broken bone to the wounds of the first created man." Similarly, in another work he writes, "I inherited the terrible *fall of Adam*, the fall made worse by his sons down the ages; the fall which I aggravate every day of my life."[31] Fr. Sophrony's point here seems to be that, while the Fall carries certain unchanging, perennial consequences, it also carries cumulative and distinctively contemporary effects. In other words, the fallen human condition changes, to some extent, with time. Typically, it gets worse. Here again the basis for Fr. Sophrony's view seems to be his teaching on the ontological unity of humanity. Since a shared—albeit fragmented—nature unites all of humanity, it makes sense that the sins of each human being *and each generation* affect the commonly held and transmitted nature.[32]

When I began reflecting on the topic of environmental ethics within Fr. Sophrony's teachings, it was exactly this point about the postlapsarian condition, including dimensions that are historically and culturally determined, that first came to my mind. When Fr. Sophrony discusses such dimensions, most of them do not refer directly to the environment, but some do. One example he notes pertains to our modern views on science. "Contemporary science," he states, "has developed considerably in the domain of mastering the forces of nature. But what a result! The Creator of nature has each time been ousted more and more from the world and the human conscience."[33] For Fr. Sophrony, the fact that people are born today into a culture that views technology as we do and seeks to master nature through science as we do is a distinctive part of our generation's inherited fallen condition. While he emphasizes the significance of changes in human attitudes for properly diagnosing the fallen

condition, it seems appropriate to extend this insight to the health of the natural world as well. Environmentally, things are getting worse—this much we know. I believe that Fr. Sophrony's account of postlapsarian anthropology can provide a theological rubric for thinking about how each human being's sins against the natural world and each generation's contributions to the sickness that permeates all creation are appropriated and passed on. Once more we see that it is his understanding of the meaning and the salvation of the human person that directs Fr. Sophrony's environmental ethics.

"The Sweat of My Brother": Conservation in Hypostatic Perspective

Perhaps one of the most profound contributions Fr. Sophrony makes to environmental issues came out only in the context of semistructured interviews I held with various members of the monastic community in Essex and pertains directly to the way he lived. Fr. Sophrony was a conservationist before "being green" became fashionable. He cared deeply about the trees on the monastery property and personally selected and oversaw the planting of different varieties on the grounds. One monastic shared with me a conversation held with him about whether or not to plant a new oak tree, given that we do not know how much time remains before Christ's Second Coming. When this monastic replied by saying, "Yes, Father, I believe it is a sign of hope for the world to plant it," he responded with a smile and said, "I'm glad you said that!"

What I heard most from the monks and nuns I interviewed, however, was that Fr. Sophrony was adamant about not wasting energy or goods. Lights, for instance, should never be on if no one is in the room. During the 1970s, as part of a conservation campaign, the British government issued stickers that could be placed around a light switch and that read, "Switch off, Save it!" Fr. Sophrony enthusiastically applied these stickers to switches throughout the monastery (and there are a few that remain up today). Similarly, to save energy and water, Fr. Sophrony would boil a full pot for tea and then pour whatever he did not use immediately into a large thermos in order to avoid having to reheat the pot. Furthermore, when the large thermos was half empty, he would pour the remaining water into a smaller thermos to keep it hot enough, thus refraining from using more gas or electricity. One monk told me that at meals Fr. Sophrony would never put more water into his glass than what he could drink, and he would never leave a drop in his glass or food on his plate. Another member of the community recalled that, in his sermons on the miraculous feeding with the loaves and fish (cf. Lk. 9:10–18; Mt. 14:13–21; Mk. 6:32–44; Jn. 6:1–14), Fr. Sophrony often focused on Jesus's instruction to "Gather up the fragments left over, that noth-

ing may be lost," offering a conservationist interpretation of the pericope. With respect to recycling, Fr. Sophrony insisted on reusing items long before such efforts became popular. When he received a letter in the mail, for example, he would cut the envelopes and use them for note taking and even for cards in the library cataloging system. To this day, members of the Community of St. John the Baptist often repurpose used envelopes for personal correspondence.

Were these aversions to "wasting" merely a reflection of Fr. Sophrony's upbringing? Was he strictly concerned about saving the monastery's limited funds? When this question arose, the answer I received was a profound expression of Fr. Sophrony's ethical vision. Yes, I was told, Fr. Sophrony was quite careful with the community's financial resources, but this was not what drove his behavior. Was it, then, his loving respect for the natural world? This, too, motivated him, I was told; however, it also was not the primary factor. What, then, was left? "Fr. Sophrony was so keen about this issue," I was told, "because he did not want to waste his brother's sweat." For Fr. Sophrony, to toss away an empty envelope meant that the human labor that went into producing that envelope was not fully respected. In addition, it meant that more work would be created for his brother, who would have to collect and dispose of the trash he generated and would have to make more notepaper to meet demand. In Fr. Sophrony's view, wasting natural resources indicated—first of all—*a lack of neighbor love*, a lack of sensitivity to the human sweat and sacrifice that go into producing goods. And, in his words, "acquiring this Love is the ultimate purpose of Christian asceticism."[34] For Fr. Sophrony, therefore, one's conservationist/ascetic relationship to nonhuman creation shapes and reflects one's hypostatic relationships with one's neighbor and with God. Waste not, for "our brother is our life." Again, it is the meaning and salvation of the human person that grounds Fr. Sophrony's environmental insights.

The Aim: Hypostatic Prayer and the Royal Priesthood

The final environmental contribution I want to note from Fr. Sophrony brings us back to the opening section on what sets human persons apart from the rest of the created world. While Fr. Sophrony was not opposed to socially conscious governmental policies—indeed, he applauded some such efforts—he gave priority to prayer. "Prayer is more important than any other activity, whether social or political, in the field of science or the arts."[35] Much insightful material has been written on the topic of "prayer for the Total Adam" in St. Silouan, what Fr. Sophrony also refers to as hypostatic prayer,

Gethsemane prayer, and liturgical prayer, and an extended discussion lies beyond our present scope.[36] Nonetheless, we should at least note that this highest of human activities encompasses not only all our fellow human beings since the beginning of history—not only each of the "milliards of leaves" on the great tree of Adam—but also the whole of nonhuman creation.[37] It is an activity possible only because of the hypostatic principle within human beings, which enables an enlargement of one's heart to cosmic proportions[38] and through which man becomes "the connecting principle between God and the rest of creation."[39] For Fr. Sophrony, hypostatic prayer is the highest expression of environmental stewardship, precisely because it both sanctifies nonhuman creation and fulfills the human person's most distinctive—and dignified—capacity. Hypostatic prayer is also an activity that Fr. Sophrony equates with the universal human calling to the "royal priesthood" (cf. 1 Pet. 2:9).[40] It reflects every human person's Eucharistic role and responsibility as a member of the body of Christ. Actualizing this highest capacity, he contends, effects a restoration and healing both within that great tree and between humanity and all other living things.[41] Hypostatic prayer, finally, is a pure expression of love, a love that participates in and imitates Christ's infinite love for us and for the world He created.

Conclusion

Neither St. Silouan nor Fr. Sophrony ever authored a systematic work on environmental ethics. Nor were either of them engaged in properly political activities with the aim of shaping public policy. They were, instead, Orthodox monks living out their calling to love God and neighbor. However, I have argued that Fr. Sophrony's written and unwritten teachings nonetheless carry important insights for critical reflection on one of the most acute social problems of our time, the condition of the natural world, and I have sought to demonstrate that for Fr. Sophrony this problem is at its core both anthropological and soteriological. Through his claims regarding the value and interconnectedness of creation, his insight into the link between environmental destruction and the current generation's fallen condition, his strict conservationism, and his affirmation of hypostatic prayer as humanity's highest calling, Fr. Sophrony enriches our understanding of environmental issues and reminds us that a hermeneutical key for examining these issues is Orthodox Christianity's theology of the person. As thinkers and church leaders continue to harvest Orthodoxy's abundant theological and ascetical tradition for resources relevant to environmental ethics, the example and teachings of Archimandrite Sophrony merit our ongoing attention.